A photograph of a monument is more than what meets the eye. It's an act of "heritagisation", says Sudeshna Guha, who has curated the exhibition, *Histories in the Making: Photographing Indian Monuments, 1855–1920*, which opens on August 31 at DAG, Delhi. This "heritagisation" through photographs is a means to choose monuments for documentation which, in turn, determines the status of many as historic monuments to be conserved. Through the showcase, Guha explores the ways in which British colonisers employed photographers and photography to capture the peoples of the subcontinent and its built heritage.

From Linnaeus Tripe's 'The Great Pagoda, The Pagoda Jewels in the Minakshi Sundareshvara Temple in Madurai' (1858) and Edmund David Lyon's 'Ramisseram Pagoda (Long Side Aisle) from Ramalingeswara Temple in Rameswaram' (1867–68) to Lala Deen Dayal's 'Sanchi Stupa' (circa 1880), the photographs didn't simply chronicle an evolution of technology, but also the gaze, especially of the colonisers, on India's history. "This is DAG's first exhibition of archival photographs, and in its focus on Indian monuments, it tells the story of the early historical surveys of India," Guha points out.

Some of the monuments photographed still remain well conserved, both physically and in the popular imagination, like the Qutub Minar in Delhi. However, some remain largely forgotten, like an ancient inner temple in Kashmir's Nowshera, documented by British photographer Samuel Bourne (1860–70). "An important thing to remember while viewing the photographs is that through such documentation, the monuments were classified into distinct categories, which erased many histories of their uses," says Guha. So, while one of the aims of the project is to spotlight what ancient Indian architecture looked like in the 19th century, another is to shed light on how such a vast photographic archive allowed for the historicising of pre-colonial India through its ruins and architecture. "This also shows how field photography brought the field into the study," adds Guha.

The exhibition explores how the British colonisers used photography to document the peoples and our built heritage

The period of 1855 to 1920 is crucial to the ways in which tools of visual documentation evolved rather rapidly, especially after the 1870s, when various types of photographs became available—from stereographs and cabinet cards to postcards. "This dramatically increased the speed of information flow," says the curator.

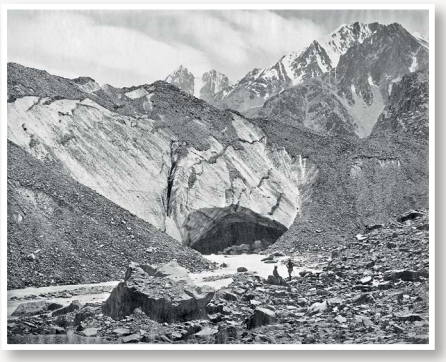
The exhibition, which goes on till October 12, interrogates the multitude of ways in which the British Raj shaped our visual histories, besides documenting how eventually their harsh authoritarian gaze began to chip away at the edges to make more room for the native eye. ■

– Arshia

PHOTOGRAPHY

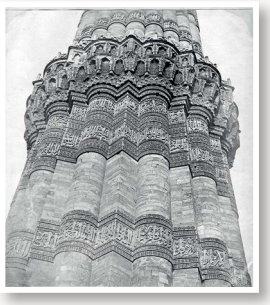
A MONUMENTAL EYE

An exhibition on Indian monuments in colonial times reveals how photography influences popular imaginations and histories









Photographs Courtesy: DAG

PAST PERFECT (Clockwise from left) Linnaeus Tripe's 'The Great Pagoda (Minakshi Sundareshvara Temple, Madurai)'; Samuel Bourne's 'Ice cave, Source of the Buspa'; Felice Beato's 'Part of the Pillar of Kootub (Qutub Minar, Delhi)'; William Henry Pigou's 'Mysore, Idol car at the temple of Chamondee (Chamundi Temple)'